

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Engineering English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For mechanical, electrical, civil, systems, industrial, test, quality, manufacturing, and field engineers, plus engineering managers and technical project leads.

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Requirements and Constraints

Clarify missing information before responding.

02 Design Reviews and Technical Pushback

State a concern respectfully and propose a practical route forward.

03 Failure Modes and Reliability

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

04 Testing, Validation, and Data Interpretation

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

05 Manufacturability and Cost Engineering

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

06 Safety Factors and Compliance

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

07 Field Issues and Customer Communication

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

08 Systems Integration and Interface Control

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Requirements and Constraints

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

A customer asks for a "lightweight and durable" enclosure without specifying weight, operating conditions, or required life.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: requirement, constraint, tolerance, tradeoff.

Model response

Could you define the target weight, operating conditions, and expected life? We need measurable requirements to discuss the tradeoffs and evaluate a design consistently.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. A - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. C - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. What does lightweight mean for this enclosure? - Fictional requirements meeting: a customer requests a lightweight, durable enclosure without numerical limits or operating conditions.
2. A close fit without a defined clearance - Fictional fixture discussion: a drawing calls for a close fit around a removable insert but specifies no clearance.
3. Quiet at which operating point? - Fictional fan-cover project: a product brief asks for quiet operation, but speed, measurement distance, and acoustic target are unspecified.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A cable that must reach

A fictional test station needs a replacement cable described as long enough. The equipment locations are known, but routing clearance, connector orientation, and required slack have not been checked. Clarify the requirement before ordering.

Role A: Design engineer: ask focused questions about the routing constraint.

Role B: Test technician: explain the station layout without inventing an unmeasured cable length.

Possible opening: Before choosing a cable length, could we confirm the route and the slack needed for maintenance?

Success checks

- Separate direct distance from routed length.
- Identify connector and maintenance constraints.
- Agree a measurement check before selecting a length.

Add a complication: The technician suggests using the straight-line distance as the complete requirement.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Design Reviews and Technical Pushback

State a concern respectfully and propose a practical route forward.

CASE

A design review is moving toward approval while one interface assumption remains undocumented.

Teach this move

Acknowledge the goal without pretending agreement. Name the specific problem and its implication, then ask a focused question or propose a next step. Be direct when a safety or ethical boundary requires it.

Vocabulary to check: design review, design rationale, risk, verification.

Model response

I support moving the review forward, but this interface assumption needs to be explicit. Could we record it and identify the verification needed before treating that part of the design as settled?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence identifies a testable concern about the proposal. It leaves room for a constructive response.

Second-round challenge

The other person repeats the request more firmly. Restate the specific concern calmly and explain the appropriate next route.

Language-check answers

1. C - The proposal assumes the review is complete; the record shows it is still open. It connects the concern to a specific assumption and record.
2. B - Could we resolve the missing approval before confirming the plan? It names the unresolved condition and a practical next step.

05 • Conversations

1. Approval with an undocumented interface assumption - Fictional design review using the lesson case: approval is being discussed while an interface assumption remains undocumented.

2. The service opening has no tool-clearance check - Fictional product review: a compact cover design is preferred, but maintenance-tool access has not been checked.

3. Removing a test because one prototype passed - Fictional review: one prototype survived a handling demonstration, and a lead proposes removing a planned repeated-handling test.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A new adhesive without reviewed evidence

A fictional assembly design uses an adhesive specified in the current drawing. A purchasing colleague proposes a substitute with a shorter lead time. Compatibility evidence is unavailable. Raise a technical concern and agree a review route, not an adhesive recommendation.

Role A: Design reviewer: explain why shorter lead time does not establish suitability.

Role B: Purchasing engineer: explain the delivery concern and ask for the evidence needed.

Possible opening: The shorter lead time helps, but we have not verified that the substitute meets this assembly's requirements.

Success checks

- Acknowledge the delivery goal.
- Distinguish a proposal from verified suitability.
- Agree who will review the substitution evidence.

Add a complication: The colleague says identical packaging descriptions should be enough.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Failure Modes and Reliability

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

A component fails during one test. The team has not reproduced the failure or checked the test setup.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: failure mode, FMEA, reliability, duty cycle.

Model response

The failure occurred in this test, but its mechanism is not established. I'll describe the observed behavior and test conditions separately from the possible explanations.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. B - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. A - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 • Conversations

1. One failure, several open explanations - Fictional reliability meeting using the lesson case: a component failed once, and neither reproduction nor test-setup checks are complete.
2. Wear after a different duty cycle - Fictional fixture trial: two samples show different wear; one ran continuously and the other ran intermittently.

3. No failures during a short trial - Fictional reliability briefing: six demonstration units ran for one afternoon without failures; expected service life has not been tested.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A connector disconnects during transport

A fictional prototype arrives with one connector disconnected. Shipping conditions were not logged, and pre-shipment inspection records have not been checked. Discuss the observation and next evidence needed without identifying a cause prematurely.

Role A: Receiving engineer: describe what you observed and what you do not know.

Role B: Reliability reviewer: ask about assembly records and transport exposure.

Possible opening: One connector was disconnected on arrival; we have not established when or why it separated.

Success checks

- State the observed failure mode precisely.
- Keep transport vibration as an unconfirmed explanation.
- Agree which existing records to review first.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to label the issue vibration failure immediately.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Testing, Validation, and Data Interpretation

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

A prototype passes a test on three samples. A presentation calls the design proven for every operating condition.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: prototype, acceptance criteria, validation, sample size.

Model response

The three samples met the criteria under the tested conditions. That does not establish performance under every condition. I'll state the sample size and limits of the test clearly.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. A - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. C - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

05 • Conversations

1. Three samples do not cover every condition - Fictional prototype review using the lesson case: three samples passed one test, but a presentation claims proof for every operating condition.
2. Average performance hides one missed criterion - Fictional latch test: four measured opening forces are 8, 9, 10, and 17 units; the project's stated individual limit is 15 units.

3. A demonstration is not an acceptance test - Fictional pump-display demonstration: the prototype ran at room temperature, while agreed acceptance testing includes additional conditions not yet tested.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Matching displayed readings, unresolved dimensions

In a fictional dimensional check, two readings display the same rounded value. The instrument resolution and raw readings have not been reviewed. Explain why matching displayed values do not yet prove identical dimensions.

Role A: Test engineer: distinguish displayed precision from the physical comparison.

Role B: Design lead: ask which measurement information is needed before interpreting the result.

Possible opening: The displayed readings match, but we need the instrument resolution before saying the dimensions are identical.

Success checks

- Explain the distinction without claiming a known difference.
- Request resolution and measurement-condition information.
- Agree wording limited to the observed readings.

Add a complication: The lead asks to remove all measurement caveats from the presentation.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Manufacturability and Cost Engineering

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

CASE

Two designs use different tooling and assembly steps. One has a lower material cost but higher assembly time.

Teach this move

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Vocabulary to check: DFM, tooling, yield, cycle time.

Model response

The material cost favors the first design, while assembly time favors the second. Let's compare the full manufacturing assumptions before calling either design cheaper overall.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. 'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Second-round challenge

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Language-check answers

1. C - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less. 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.
2. B - An increase of one percentage point. Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

05 · Conversations

1. Cheaper material, longer assembly - Fictional design comparison using the lesson case: one option has lower material cost but takes longer to assemble; tooling differs.
2. A faster cycle with more rejected parts - Fictional pilot comparison: process A produces 100 parts per hour with 90 accepted; process B produces 95 with 93 accepted in one trial each.

3. Tooling cost depends on the volume assumption - Fictional enclosure review: a machined option avoids dedicated tooling; a molded option requires tooling, while the production quantity is not confirmed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Two fasteners or a snap fit?

A fictional cover can use two screws or a proposed snap fit. The screw assembly time has been measured; snap-fit assembly time and rework behavior have not. Compare the options without assuming the new design is faster or cheaper.

Role A: Design engineer: explain the proposed reduction in parts.

Role B: Manufacturing engineer: ask for comparable assembly and rework evidence.

Possible opening: The snap fit removes two screws, but we haven't measured its assembly or rework performance yet.

Success checks

- Use common criteria for both options.
- Separate fewer parts from demonstrated lower cost.
- Propose a bounded comparison and preserve unknown results.

Add a complication: A manager wants a cost-saving percentage before the trial.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Safety Factors and Compliance

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

A review note says a design is "compliant" without identifying the applicable requirement or review evidence.

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: safety factor, code compliance, margin, liability.

Model response

Could you identify the requirement, revision, and supporting evidence for that statement? We need a traceable basis for the compliance claim and review by the responsible specialist.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. B - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.
2. A - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

05 · Conversations

1. Which requirement supports compliant? - Fictional engineering review using the lesson case: a note says compliant but identifies neither an applicable requirement nor supporting review evidence.
2. A safety factor without its load basis - Fictional internal calculation review: a summary lists a safety factor of two but omits the load case and calculation revision.

3. A supplier certificate names another revision - Fictional equipment review: a supplier certificate names revision B, while the supplied assembly is labeled revision C; equivalence has not been established.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The unsigned review page

A fictional design package contains a completed calculation and an unsigned review page. The reviewer's availability is unknown. Request status and supporting evidence without treating a completed calculation as completed independent review.

Role A: Engineering coordinator: ask what review occurred and what remains pending.

Role B: Design engineer: distinguish calculation completion from review confirmation.

Possible opening: The calculation is present, but could you confirm whether the independent review has actually occurred?

Success checks

- Do not infer approval from precedent.
- Request confirmation through the appropriate reviewer.
- Agree a status checkpoint without inventing availability.

Add a complication: Someone suggests adding the reviewer's name because they usually approve similar work.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Field Issues and Customer Communication

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

CASE

A customer received a field-failure update that stated an unconfirmed cause as fact. The investigation is still open.

Teach this move

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Vocabulary to check: field failure, warranty, corrective action, installation condition.

Model response

Our earlier update overstated the cause. The investigation is still open, and the confirmed finding is the observed failure described below. I'm sorry for the confusion; we'll clearly label hypotheses in future updates.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision takes responsibility for the message without blaming the listener. It identifies what needs to be corrected.

Second-round challenge

The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Language-check answers

1. A - I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear. This acknowledges the speaker's contribution to the problem.
2. C - The corrected date and the current confirmation status. A repair needs usable corrected information, including any uncertainty.

05 · Conversations

1. Correcting an unconfirmed field-failure cause - Fictional customer update using the lesson case: a previous message presented an unconfirmed field-failure cause as fact; investigation remains open.
2. A replacement shipment is not proof of a fix - Fictional service case: a replacement display has shipped after a field failure, but the cause and corrective-action effectiveness are unconfirmed.

3. No fault found does not erase the report - Fictional returned-unit investigation: a display worked during a bench check, but the customer's intermittent field symptom has not been reproduced.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | An interim report incorrectly labeled final

A fictional customer received a test summary headed Final Update, although two inspection results remain pending. No cause is confirmed. Correct the communication and agree how the next update will distinguish findings from open work.

Role A: Service engineer: acknowledge the misleading heading and explain current status.

Role B: Customer maintenance coordinator: ask what can be shared with colleagues now.

Possible opening: The heading was misleading: this is an interim update, and two inspection results are still pending.

Success checks

- Acknowledge the specific communication error.
- Preserve confirmed results without inventing a cause.
- Agree a clear next update and ownership.

Add a complication: The customer asks whether the heading error means all test results are unreliable.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Systems Integration and Interface Control

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

CASE

A hardware interface changed after software testing began. The integration team needs the version and affected tests.

Teach this move

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

Vocabulary to check: interface control, integration, regression test, configuration management.

Model response

The interface changed in this revision. I've listed the affected signals and tests for review. Please confirm the configuration your team will use and which checks need to be repeated.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence asks for an identifiable receiving team instead of leaving responsibility with an unspecified 'someone'.

Second-round challenge

The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Language-check answers

1. C - Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check. It asks for an identifiable person or team responsible for the task.
2. B - So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct? This repeats the status and responsibility and invites correction.

05 • Conversations

1. Which interface version did software test? - Fictional integration handoff using the lesson case: hardware changed after software testing began, and the receiving team needs the version and affected tests.

2. A unit change in the sensor message - Fictional integration case: interface revision 4 reports temperature in Celsius; revision 5 specifies kelvin. Existing software tests used revision 4.

3. Matching filenames conceal different configurations - Fictional test handoff: two configuration files share a filename but have different revision identifiers; the tested identifier is recorded.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A timeout changed between components

In a fictional integration, the controller timeout changes from five seconds to three in a proposed revision. The receiving application was tested with five seconds. The proposal is not released. Give a handoff that preserves that status and identifies test impact.

Role A: Controller engineer: explain the proposed value and release status.

Role B: Integration lead: confirm the tested configuration and ask about regression review.

Possible opening: The proposed revision shortens the timeout to three seconds, but it has not been released or integration-tested.

Success checks

- Distinguish proposed, released, and tested configurations.
- Identify the timing-dependent tests as needing review.
- Confirm the receiver understands which file may be used.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to put the proposed file into the release package because its revision number is newer.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.